39.3: Responses to light are critical for plant success

Light is an especially important environmental factor in the lives of plants. In addition to being required for photosynthesis, light triggers many key events in plant growth and development, collectively known as **photomorphogenesis**. Light reception also allows plants to measure the passage of days and seasons.

Plants detect not only the presence of light signals but also their direction, intensity, and wavelength (color). A graph called an **action spectrum** depicts the relative effectiveness of different wavelengths of radiation in driving a particular process, such as photosynthesis (see Figure 10.9b). Action spectra are useful in studying *any* process that depends on light. By comparing action spectra of various plant responses, researchers determine which responses are mediated by the same photoreceptor (pigment). They also compare action spectra with absorption spectra of pigments; a close correspondence for a given pigment suggests that the pigment is the photoreceptor mediating the response. Action spectra reveal that red and blue light are the most important colors in regulating a plant's photomorphogenesis. These observations led researchers to two major classes of light receptors: blue-light photoreceptors and phytochromes.

Blue-Light Photoreceptors

Pigments that absorb blue light, known as **blue-light photoreceptors**, initiate a variety of responses in plants, including phototropism, the light-induced opening of stomata (see Figure 36.14), and the light-induced slowing of hypocotyl elongation that occurs when a seedling breaks ground. The biochemical identity of the blue-light photoreceptor was so elusive that in the 1970s, plant physiologists began to call this receptor "cryptochrome" (from the Greek *kryptos*, hidden, and *chrom*, pigment). In the 1990s, molecular biologists analyzing *Arabidopsis* mutants found that plants use different types of pigments to detect blue light. *Cryptochromes*, molecular relatives of DNA repair enzymes, are involved in the blue-light-induced inhibition of stem elongation that occurs, for example, when a seedling first emerges from the soil. *Phototropin* is a protein kinase involved in mediating blue-light-mediated stomatal opening, chloroplast movements in response to light, and phototropic curvatures **(Figure 39.15)**, such as those studied by the Darwins.

Figure 39.15

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Action spectrum for blue-light-stimulated phototropism in maize coleoptiles.
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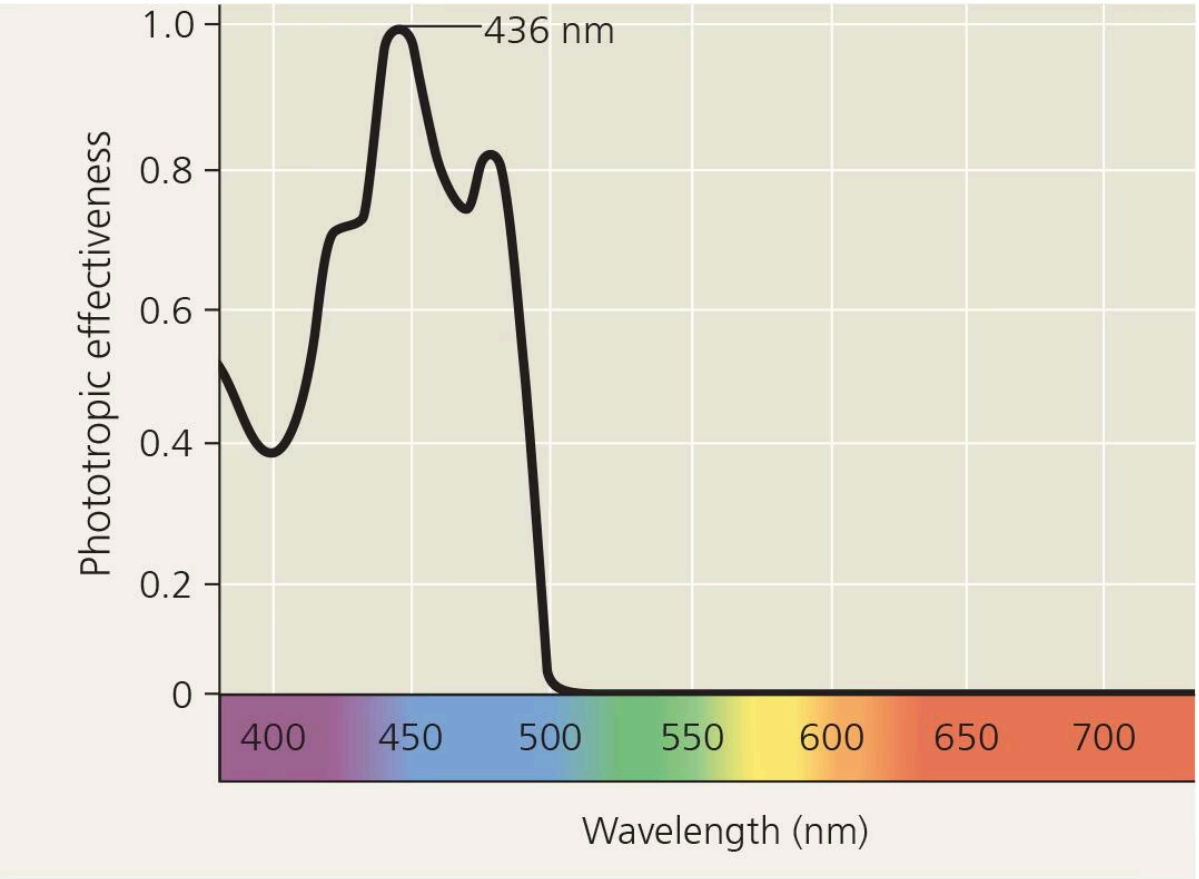
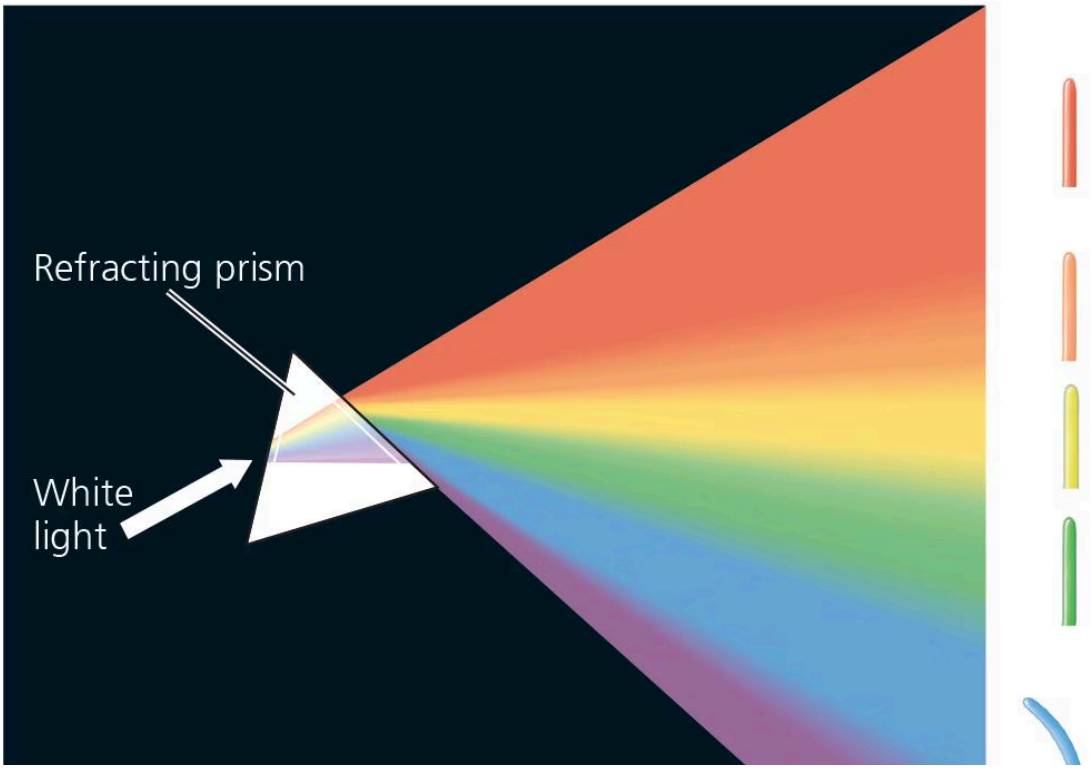


(a) This action spectrum illustrates that only light wavelengths below 500 nm (blue and violet light) induce curvature.



(b) When coleoptiles are exposed to light of various wavelengths as shown here, violet light induces slight curvature toward the light and blue light induces the most curvature. The other colors do not induce any curvature.

Phototropic bending toward light is controlled by phototropin, a photoreceptor sensitive to blue and violet light, particularly blue light.

Part a. The graph plots Phototropic effectiveness versus wavelength in nanometers. This action spectrum illustrates that only light wavelengths below 500 nanometers (blue and violet light) induce curvature. The graph rises and falls between 0.4 and 1.0 phototropic effectiveness for violet and blue light, with a peak at 436 nanometers. It then flatlines after blue.

Part b. A refracting prism receives white light and generates pure colored light. Coleoptiles curve towards the light as follows: red, orange, yellow, and green , no curvature; blue, significant curvature; violet, some curvature.

Video

Phototropism

Play

Play

Phytochrome Photoreceptors

When exploring signal transduction in plants earlier in the chapter, we looked at the role of the plant pigments called phytochromes in the de-etiolation process. **Phytochromes**, pigments that absorb mostly red light and far-red light—that is, light of wavelengths near the upper edge of human visibility (730 nm)—regulate many plant responses to light, including seed germination and shade avoidance.

Phytochromes and Seed Germination

Studies of seed germination led to the discovery of phytochromes. Because of limited nutrient reserves, many types of seeds, especially small ones, germinate only when the light environment and other conditions are near optimal. Such seeds often remain dormant for years until light conditions change. For example, the death of a shading tree or the plowing of a field may create a favorable light environment for germination.

In the 1930s, scientists determined the action spectrum for light-induced germination of lettuce seeds. They exposed water-swollen seeds to a few minutes of single-colored light of various wavelengths and then stored the seeds in the dark. After two days, the researchers counted the number of seeds that had germinated under each light regimen. They found that red light of wavelength 660 nm increased the germination percentage of lettuce seeds maximally, whereas far-red light *inhibited* germination compared with dark

controls **(Figure 39.16)**. What happens when the lettuce seeds are subjected to a flash of red light followed by a flash of far-red light or, conversely, to far-red light followed by red light? The *last* flash of light determines the seeds' response: The effects of red and far-red light are reversible.

Figure 39.16

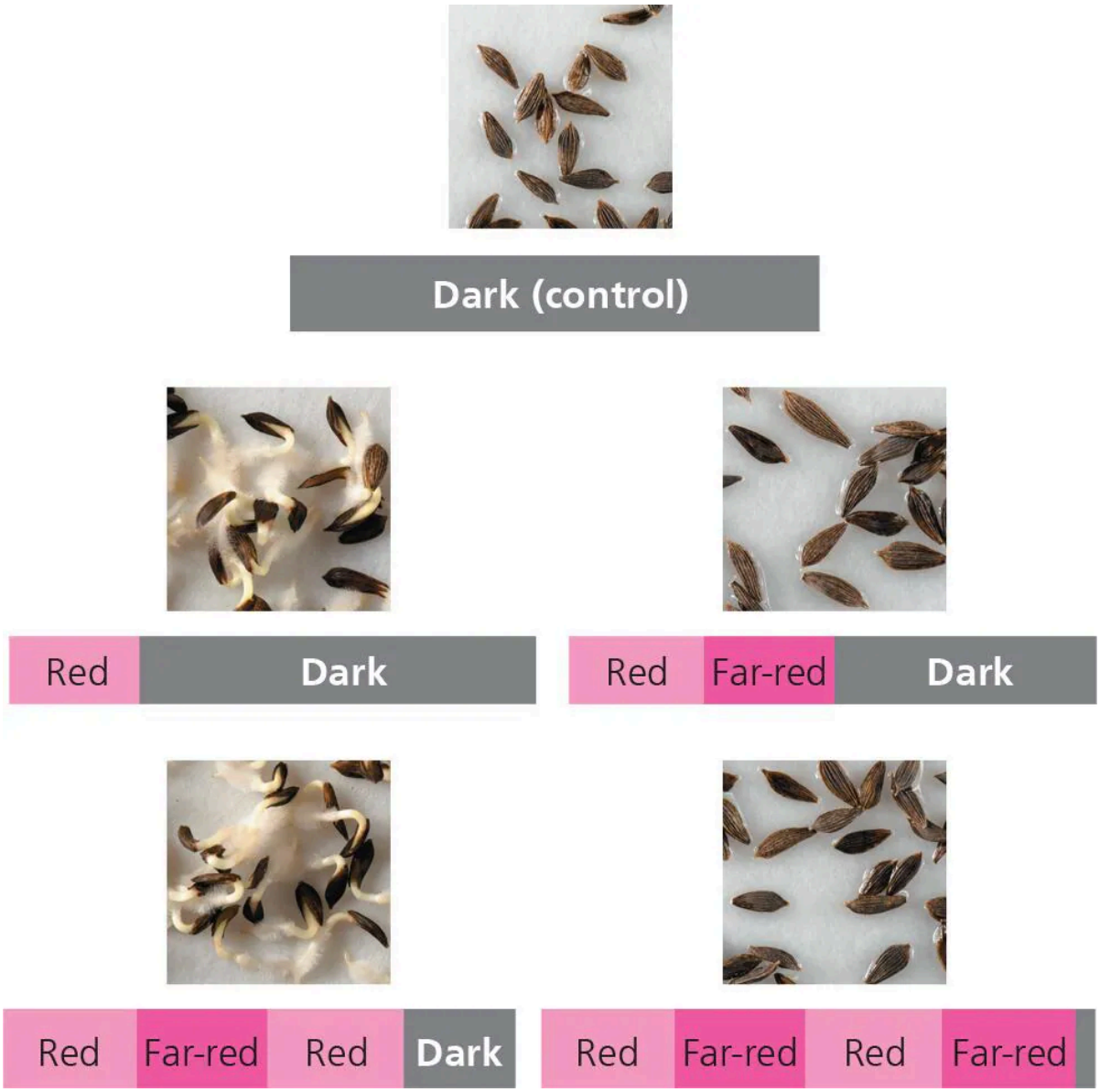
Inquiry: How does the order of red and far-red illumination affect seed germination?

Experiment

Scientists at the U.S. Department of Agriculture briefly exposed batches of lettuce seeds to red light or far-red light to test the effects on germination. After the light exposure, the seeds were placed in the dark, and the results were compared with control seeds that were not exposed to light.

Results

The bar below each photo indicates the sequence of red light exposure, far-red light exposure, and darkness. The germination rate increased greatly in groups of seeds that were last exposed to red light (left). Germination was inhibited in groups of seeds that were last exposed to far-red light (right).



Dark (control): no germination; Red, dark: germination; Red, far-red, dark: no germination; Red, far-red, red, dark: germination; Red, far-red, red, far-red: no germination. The germination rate increased greatly in groups of seeds that were last exposed to red light. Germination was inhibited in groups of seeds that were last exposed to far-red light.

Data from H. Borthwick et al., A reversible photoreaction controlling seed germination, *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences USA* 38:662–666 (1952).

Conclusion

Red light stimulates germination, and far-red light inhibits germination. The final light exposure is the determining factor. The effects of red and far-red light are reversible.

WHAT IF? *Phytochrome responds faster to red light than to far-red light. If the seeds had been placed in white light instead of the dark after their red light and far-red light treatments, would the results have been different?*

*For suggested answer, see*Appendix A.**

The photoreceptors responsible for the opposing effects of red and far-red light are phytochromes. So far, researchers have identified five phytochromes in *Arabidopsis*, each with a slightly different polypeptide component. In most phytochromes, the light-absorbing portion is photoreversible, converting back and forth between two forms, depending on the color of light to which it is exposed. In its red-absorbing form (Pr), a phytochrome absorbs red (r) light maximally and is converted to its far-red-absorbing form (Pfr); in its Pfr form, it absorbs far-red (fr) light and is converted to its Pr form **(Figure 39.17)**. This Pr↔Pfr interconversion is a switching mechanism that controls various light-induced events in the life of the plant. Pfr is the form of phytochrome that triggers many of a plant's developmental responses to light. For example, Pr in lettuce seeds exposed to red light is converted to Pfr, stimulating the cellular responses that lead to germination. When red-illuminated seeds are then exposed to far-red light, the Pfr is converted back to Pr, inhibiting the germination response.

Figure 39.17

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Phytochrome: a molecular switching mechanism.
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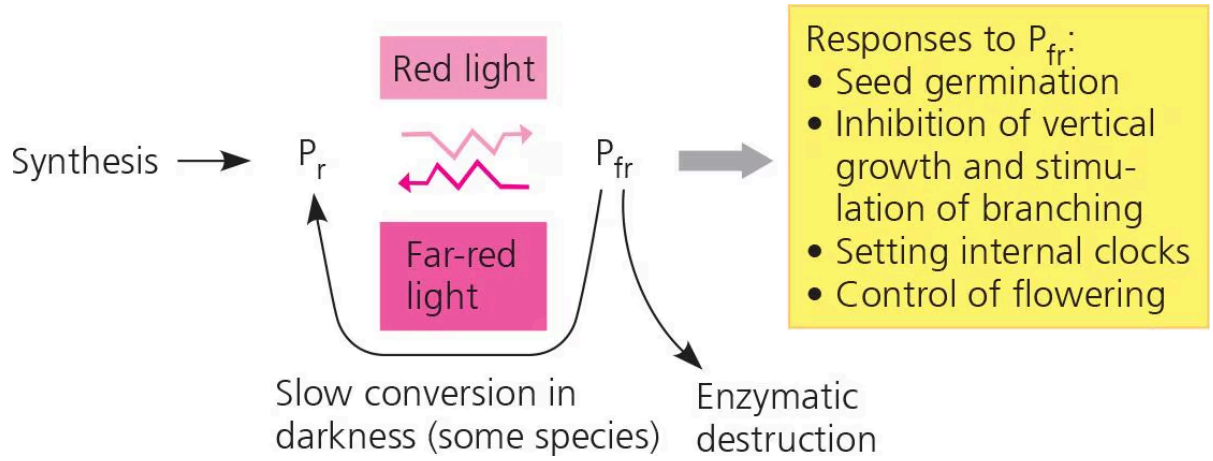

Plants synthesize phytochrome in P sub r form. Red light causes P sub r conversion to P sub f r (rapid conversion). Responses to P sub f r include: Seed germination; Inhibition of vertical growth and stimulation of branching; Setting internal clocks; Control of flowering. Exposure to far-red light causes a slow conversion in darkness (some species) of P sub f r back to P sub r.

The absorption of red light causes Pr to change to Pfr. Far-red light reverses this conversion. In most cases, it is the Pfr form of the pigment that switches on physiological and developmental responses in the plant.

How does phytochrome switching explain light-induced germination in nature? Plants synthesize phytochrome as Pr, and if seeds are kept in the dark, the pigment remains almost entirely in the Pr form (see Figure 39.17). Sunlight contains both red light and far-red light, but the conversion to Pfr is faster than the conversion to Pr. Therefore, the ratio of Pfr to Pr increases in the sunlight. When seeds are exposed to adequate sunlight, the production and accumulation of Pfr trigger their germination.

Phytochromes and Shade Avoidance

The phytochrome system also provides the plant with information about the *quality* of light. Because sunlight includes both red and far-red radiation, during the day the Pr↔Pfr interconversion reaches a dynamic equilibrium, with the ratio of the two phytochrome forms indicating the relative amounts of red and far-red light. This sensing mechanism enables plants to adapt to changes in light conditions. Consider, for example, the "shade avoidance" response of a tree that requires relatively high light intensity. If other trees in a forest shade this tree, the phytochrome ratio shifts in favor of Pr because the forest canopy screens out more red light than far-red light. This is because the chlorophyll pigments in the leaves of the canopy absorb red light and allow far-red light to pass. The shift in the ratio of red to far-red light induces the tree to allocate more of its resources to growing taller. In contrast, direct sunlight increases the proportion of Pfr, which stimulates branching and inhibits vertical growth.

In addition to helping plants detect light, phytochrome helps a plant keep track of the passage of days and seasons. To understand phytochrome's role in these timekeeping processes, we must first examine the nature of the plant's internal clock.

Biological Clocks and Circadian Rhythms

Many plant processes, such as transpiration and the synthesis of certain enzymes, undergo a daily oscillation. Some of these cyclic variations are responses to the changes in light levels and temperature that accompany the 24-hour cycle of day and night. We can control these external factors by growing plants in growth chambers under rigidly maintained conditions of light and temperature. But even under artificially constant conditions, many physiological processes in plants, such as the opening and closing of stomata and the production of photosynthetic enzymes, continue to oscillate with a frequency of about 24 hours. For example, many legumes lower their leaves in the evening and raise them in the morning **(Figure 39.18)**. A bean plant continues these "sleep movements" even if kept in constant light or constant darkness; the leaves are not simply responding to sunrise and sunset. Such cycles, with a frequency of about 24 hours and not directly controlled by any known environmental variable, are called **circadian rhythms** (from the Latin *circa*, approximately, and *dies*, day).

Figure 39.18

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“Sleep movements” of a bean plant (*Phaseolus vulgaris*).
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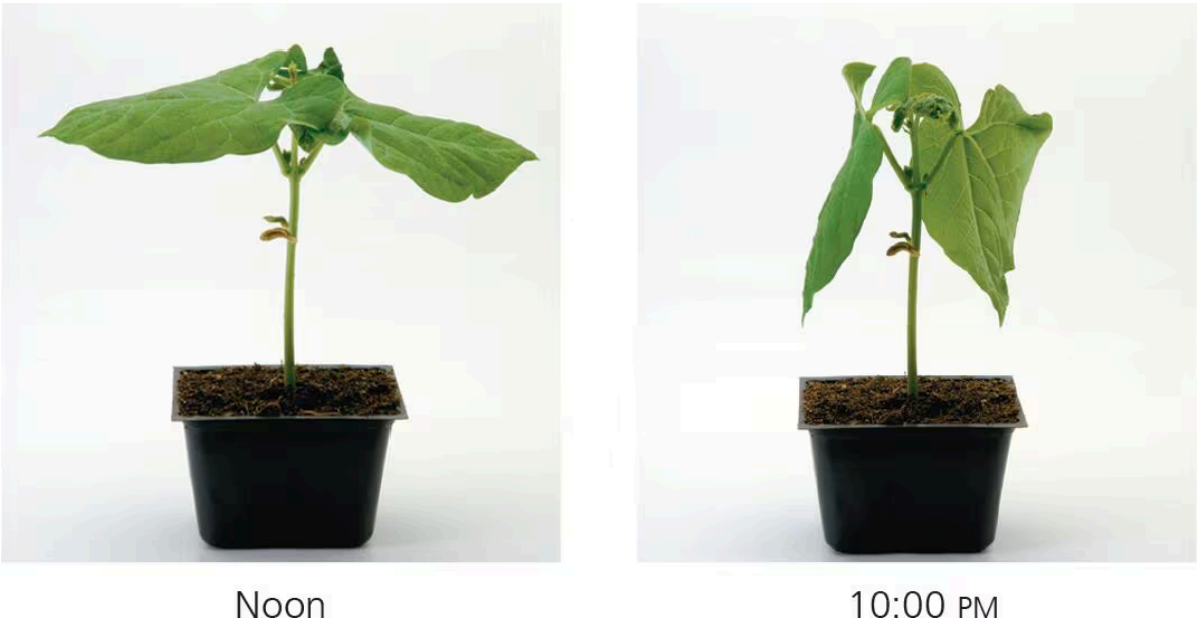

The movements are caused by reversible changes in the turgor pressure of cells on opposing sides of the pulvini, motor organs of the leaf. This behavior may facilitate the hunting of herbivores by nocturnal predators, such as bats and owls, thereby benefiting the plant.

Recent research supports the idea that the molecular “gears” of the circadian clock really are internal and not a daily response to some subtle but pervasive environmental cycle, such as geomagnetism or cosmic radiation. Organisms, including plants and humans, continue their rhythms even after being placed in deep mine shafts or when orbited in satellites, conditions that alter these subtle geophysical periodicities. However, daily signals from the environment can entrain (set) the circadian clock to a period of precisely 24 hours.

If an organism is kept in a constant environment, its circadian rhythms deviate from a 24-hour period (a period is the duration of one cycle). These free-running periods, as they are called, vary from about 21 to 27 hours, depending on the particular rhythmic response. The “sleep movements” of bean plants, for instance, have a period of 26hours when the plants are kept in the free-running condition of constant darkness. Deviation of the free-running period from exactly 24hours does not mean that biological clocks drift erratically. Free-running clocks are still keeping perfect time, but they are not synchronized with the outside world. To understand the mechanisms underlying circadian rhythms, we must distinguish between the clock and the rhythmic processes it controls. For example, the leaves of the bean plant in Figure 39.18 are the

clock's "hands" but are not the essence of the clock itself. If bean leaves are restrained for several hours and then released, they will reestablish the position appropriate for the time of day. We can interfere with a biological rhythm, but the underlying clockwork continues to tick.

At the heart of the molecular mechanisms underlying circadian rhythms are oscillations in the transcription of certain genes. Mathematical models propose that the 24-hour period arises from negative-feedback loops involving the transcription of a few central "clock genes." Some clock genes may encode transcription factors that inhibit, after a time delay, the transcription of the gene that encodes the transcription factor itself. Such negative-feedback loops, together with a time delay, are enough to produce oscillations.

Researchers have used a novel technique to identify clock mutants of *Arabidopsis*. One prominent circadian rhythm in plants is the daily production of certain photosynthesis-related proteins. Molecular biologists traced the source of this rhythm to the promoter that initiates the transcription of the genes for these photosynthesis proteins. To identify clock mutants, scientists inserted the gene for an enzyme responsible for the bioluminescence of fireflies, called luciferase, to the promoter. When the biological clock turned on the promoter in the *Arabidopsis* genome, it also turned on the production of luciferase. The plants began to glow with a circadian periodicity. Clock mutants were then isolated by selecting specimens that glowed for a longer or shorter time than normal. The genes altered in some of these mutants affect proteins that normally bind photoreceptors. Perhaps these particular mutations disrupt a light-dependent mechanism that sets the biological clock.

Interview

Interview with Ruth Satter: Investigating "sleep movements" in plants

The Effect of Light on the Biological Clock

As previously noted, the free-running period of the circadian rhythm of bean leaf movements is 26 hours. Consider a bean plant placed at dawn in a dark cabinet for 72hours: Its leaves would not rise again until 2 hours after natural dawn on the second day, 4hours after natural dawn on the third day, and so on. Shut off

from environmental cues, the plant becomes desynchronized. Desynchronization happens to humans when we fly across several time zones; when we reach our destination, the clocks on the wall are not synchronized with our internal clocks. Most organisms are probably prone to jet lag.

The factor that entrains the biological clock to precisely 24 hours every day is light. Both phytochromes and blue-light photoreceptors can entrain circadian rhythms in plants, but our understanding of how phytochromes do this is more complete. The mechanism involves turning cellular responses on and off by means of the Pr↔Pfr switch.

Consider again the photoreversible system in Figure 39.17. In darkness, the phytochrome ratio shifts gradually in favor of the Pr form, partly as a result of turnover in the overall phytochrome pool. The pigment is synthesized in the Pr form, and enzymes destroy more Pfr than Pr. In some plant species, Pfr present at sundown slowly converts to Pr. In darkness, there is no means for the Pr to be reconverted to Pfr, but upon illumination, the Pfr level suddenly increases again as Pr is rapidly converted. This increase in Pfr each day at dawn resets the biological clock: Bean leaves reach their most extreme night position 16 hours after dawn.

In nature, interactions between phytochrome and the biological clock enable plants to measure the passage of night and day. The relative lengths of night and day, however, change over the course of the year (except at the equator). Plants use this change to adjust activities in timing with the seasons.

Photoperiodism and Responses to Seasons

Imagine the consequences if a plant produced flowers when pollinators were not present or if a deciduous tree produced leaves in the middle of winter. Seasonal events are of critical importance in the life cycles of most plants. Seed germination, flowering, and the onset and breaking of bud dormancy are all stages that usually occur at specific times of the year. The environmental cue that plants use to detect the time of year is the change in day length (*photoperiod*). A physiological response to specific night or day lengths, such as flowering, is called **photoperiodism**.

Photoperiodism and Control of Flowering

An early clue to how plants detect seasons came from a mutant variety of tobacco, Maryland Mammoth, that grew tall but failed to flower during summer. It finally bloomed in a greenhouse in December. After trying to induce earlier flowering by varying temperature, moisture, and mineral nutrition, researchers learned that the shortening days of winter stimulated this variety to flower. Experiments revealed that flowering occurred only if the photoperiod was 14 hours or shorter. This variety did not flower during summer because at Maryland's latitude the photoperiods were too long.

The researchers called Maryland Mammoth a **short-day plant** because it apparently required a light period *shorter* than a critical length to flower. Chrysanthemums, poinsettias, and some soybean varieties are also short-day plants, which generally flower in late summer, fall, or winter. Another group of plants flower only when the light period is *longer* than a certain number of hours. These **long-day plants** generally flower in late spring or early summer. Spinach, for example, flowers when days are 14 hours or longer. Radishes, lettuce, irises, and many cereal varieties are also long-day plants. **Day-neutral plants**, such as tomatoes, rice, and dandelions, are unaffected by photoperiod and flower when they reach a certain stage of maturity, regardless of photoperiod.

Critical Night Length

In the 1940s, researchers learned that flowering in short- and long-day plants is actually controlled by night length, not day length (photoperiod). Many of these scientists worked with cocklebur (*Xanthium strumarium*), a short-day plant that flowers only when days are 16 hours or shorter (and nights are at least 8 hours long). These researchers found that if the photoperiod is broken by a brief exposure to darkness, flowering proceeds. However, if the night length is interrupted by even a few minutes of dim light, cocklebur will not flower, and this turned out to be true for other short-day plants as well **(Figure 39.19a)**. Cocklebur is unresponsive to day length, but it requires at least 8 hours of continuous darkness to flower. Short-day plants are really long-night plants, but the older term is embedded firmly in the lexicon of plant physiology. Similarly, long-day plants are actually short-night plants. A long-day plant grown under long-night conditions that would not normally induce flowering will flower if the night length is interrupted by a few minutes of light **(Figure 39.19b)**.

Figure 39.19

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Photoperiodic control of flowering.
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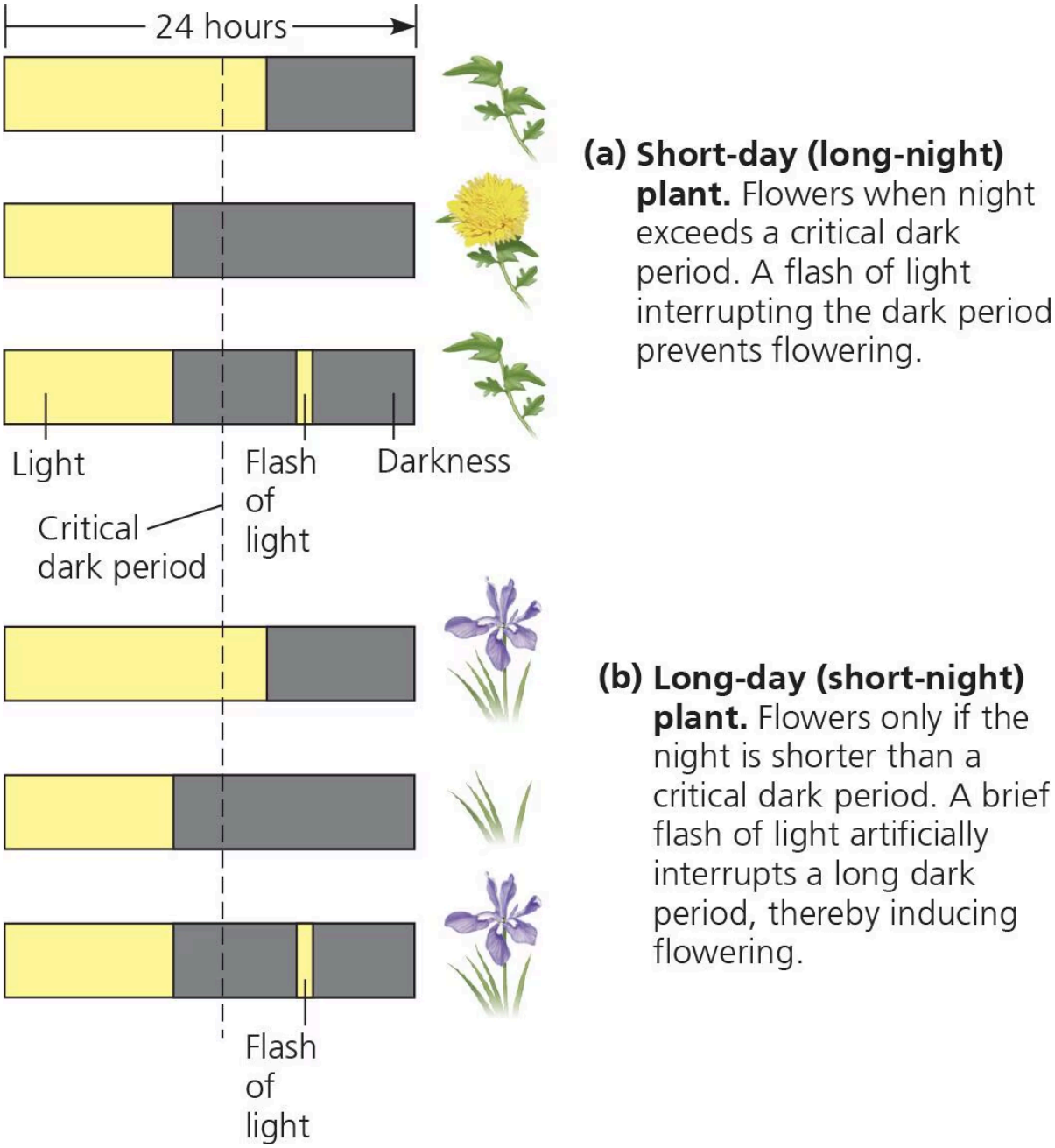

Part a. Short-day (long-night) plant. Plant flowers when the duration of night exceeds a critical amount of darkness (24 hour day). If flash of light interrupts the dark period flowering is prevented

Part b. Long-day (short-night) plant. Flowers only if night duration is shorter than a critical dark period (24 hour day). If long dark period is artificially interrupted by brief flash of light, flowering is induced.

Notice that long-day plants are *not* distinguished from short-day plants by an absolute night length. Instead, they are distinguished by whether the critical night length sets a *maximum* number of hours of darkness required for flowering (long-day plants) or a *minimum* number of hours of darkness required for flowering (short-day plants). In both cases, the actual number of hours in the critical night length is specific to each species of plant.

Red light is the most effective color in interrupting the night length. Action spectra and photoreversibility experiments show that phytochrome is the pigment that detects the red light **(Figure 39.20)**. For example, if a flash of red light during the night length is followed by a flash of far-red light, then the plant detects no interruption of night length. As in the case of phytochrome-mediated seed germination, red/far-red photoreversibility occurs.

Figure 39.20

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Reversible effects of red and far-red light on photoperiodic response.
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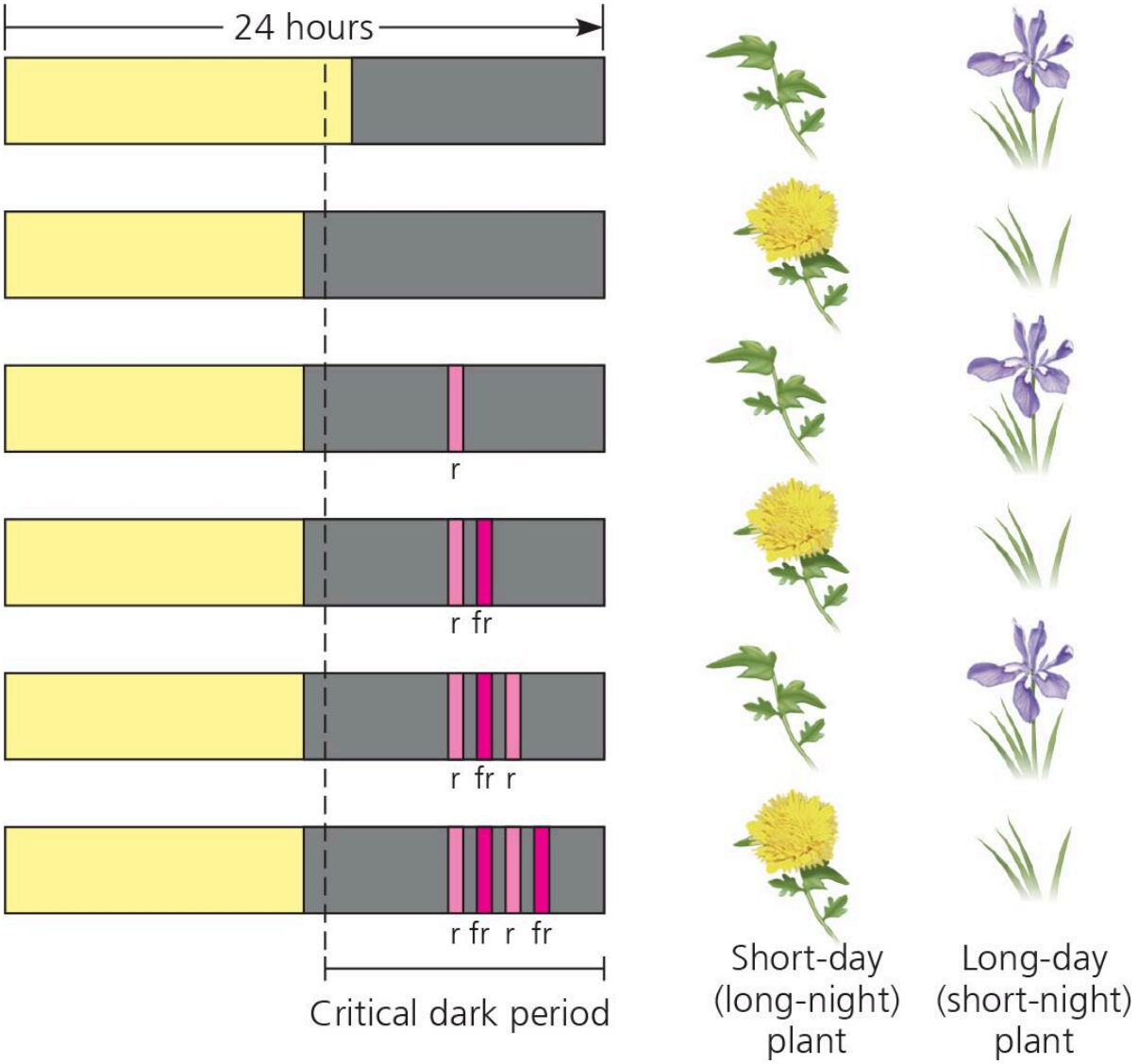

A flash of red (r) light shortens the dark period. A subsequent flash of far-red (fr) light cancels the red flash's effect.

A table explains the results:

24 Hour Day	Short-day (long-night) plant	Long-day (short-night) plant
Daylight exceeds critical dark period	No flowering	Flowering
Night exceeds critical dark period	Flowering	No flowering
Night exceeds critical dark period, flash of red light during darkness	No flowering	Flowering
Night exceeds critical dark period, flash of red light followed by flash of far-red light during darkness	Flowering	No flowering
Night exceeds critical dark period, flash of red light followed by flash of far-red light followed by flash of red light during darkness	No flowering	Flowering
Night exceeds critical dark period, flash of red light followed by flash of far-red light followed by flash of red light followed by flash of far-red light during darkness	Flowering	No flowering

VISUAL SKILLS*Under long-day conditions (as in the top panel) or under short-day conditions (as in the second panel), how would a single flash of far-red light during the dark period affect flowering?*

*For suggested answer, see*Appendix A*.*

Plants measure night lengths very precisely; some short-day plants will not flower if night is even 1 minute shorter than the critical length. Some plant species always flower on the same day each year. It appears that plants use their biological clock, entrained by night length with the help of phytochrome, to tell the season of the year. The floriculture (flower-growing) industry applies this knowledge to produce flowers out of season. Chrysanthemums, for instance, are short-day plants that normally bloom in fall, but their blooming can be stalled until Mother's Day in May by punctuating each long night with a flash of light, thus turning one long night into two short nights.

Some plants bloom after a single exposure to the photoperiod required for flowering. Other species need several successive days of the appropriate photoperiod. Still others respond to a photoperiod only if they have been previously exposed to some other environmental stimulus, such as a period of cold. Winter wheat, for example, will not flower unless it has been exposed to several weeks of temperatures below 10°C. The use of pretreatment with cold to induce flowering is called **vernalization** (from the Latin for "spring"). Several weeks after winter wheat is vernalized, a long photoperiod (short night) induces flowering.

A Flowering Hormone?

Although flowers form from apical or axillary bud meristems, it is leaves that detect changes in photoperiod and produce signaling molecules that cue buds to develop as flowers. In many short-day and long-day plants, exposing just one leaf to the appropriate photoperiod is enough to induce flowering. Indeed, as long as one leaf is left on the plant, photoperiod is detected and floral buds are induced. If all leaves are removed, the plant is insensitive to photoperiod.

Classic experiments revealed that the floral stimulus could move across a graft from an induced plant to a noninduced plant and trigger flowering in the latter. Moreover, the flowering stimulus appears to be the same for short-day and long-day plants, despite the different photoperiodic conditions required for leaves to send this signal **(Figure 39.21)**. The hypothetical signaling molecule for flowering, called **florigen**, remained unidentified for over 70 years as scientists focused on small hormone-like molecules. However, large macromolecules, such as mRNA and proteins, can move by the symplastic route via plasmodesmata and regulate plant development. It now appears that florigen is a protein. A gene called *FLOWERING LOCUS T* (*FT*) is activated in leaf cells during conditions favoring flowering, and the FT protein travels through the symplasm to the shoot apical meristem, initiating the transition of a bud's meristem from a vegetative to a flowering state.

Figure 39.21

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Experimental evidence for a flowering hormone.
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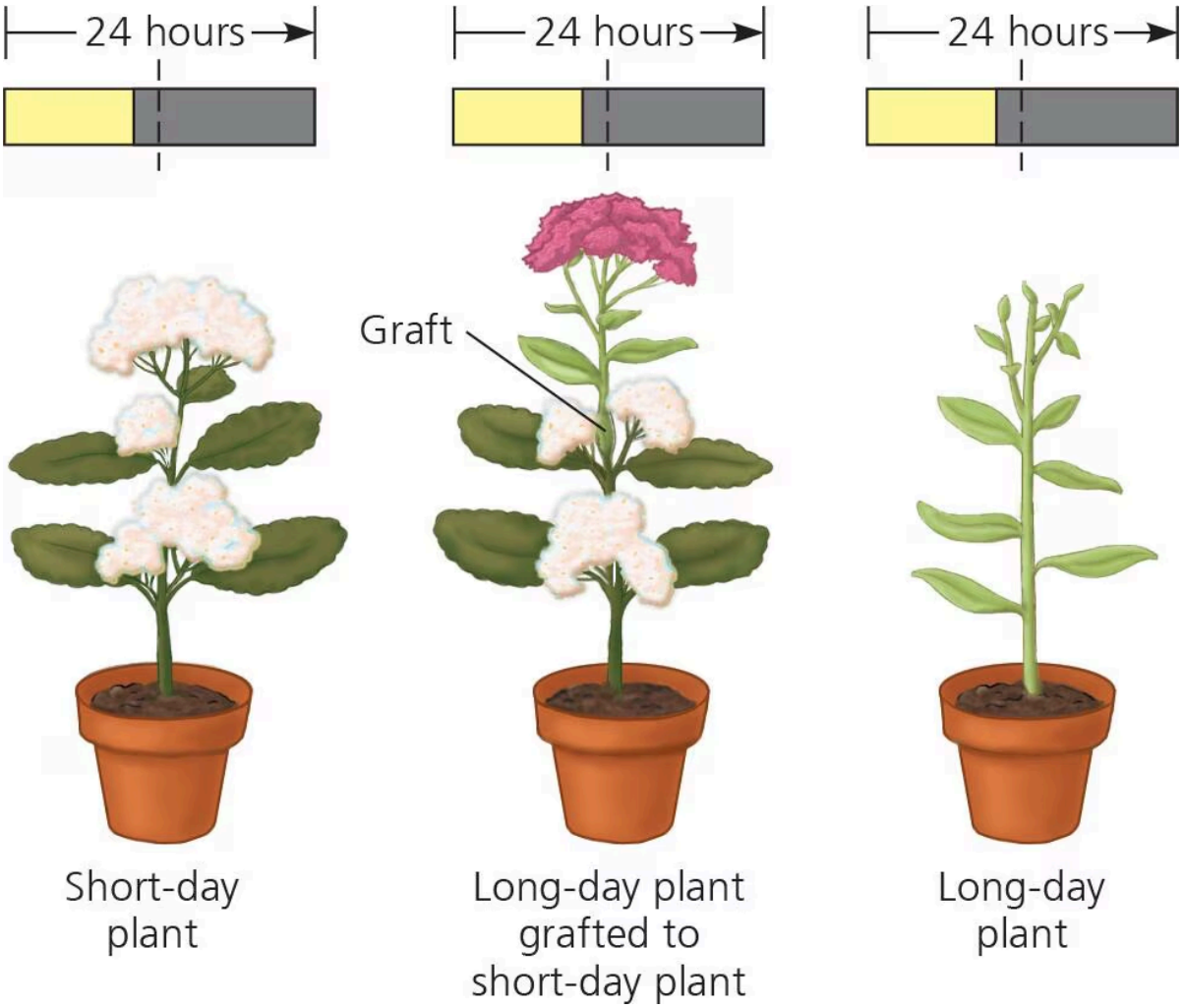

If grown individually under short-day conditions, a short-day plant will flower and a long-day plant will not. However, both will flower if grafted together and exposed to short days. This result indicates that a flower-inducing substance (florigen) is transmitted across grafts and induces flowering in both short-day and long-day plants.

WHAT IF?** *If flowering were inhibited in both parts of the grafted plants, what would you conclude?*

*For suggested answer, see*Appendix A.**